success.[46] Once in the premiership, Gandhi expressed appreciation for Johnson's efforts toward peace in Vietnam.[47] Through B. K. Nehru, she also conveyed her disappointment at Moscow and Hanoi's lack of response.[48] Indian officials further indicated that they would approach Soviet officials privately, but made no promises on public declarations of support, asserting that those would decrease Indian influence with Hanoi and Moscow.[49]

In terms of what else India could do to help, Rusk had suggested that Johnson urge it to move further toward liberal economic policies and a greater focus on agriculture.[50] Komer expected Indian movement on economic reforms, but not on Vietnam or Pakistan because of Gandhi's domestic political situation. Nevertheless, even on the latter issues, he believed that the Indian need for the US could lead to a shift. He stated that "we have a strong ally moving India toward us on these matters—Mao Tse-tung.… The Indians are increasingly serious about China, and all we need do is nudge this trend along." Komer asserted, however, that the US needed to calibrate that nudging carefully.[51]

Johnson understood the domestic pressure on the new Indian prime minister, who, like himself, had found herself in that position on the sudden death of her predecessor. He assured the Indian ambassador that, to help strengthen Gandhi's position, the US would not pressure her when she visited Washington in March 1966, as her opposition would expect.[52] During her visit, Gandhi on her part showed a willingness to move forward on improving India-Pakistan relations and economic reforms.[53] She publicly asserted that India was committed to battling the communist Chinese threat. Beijing was not amused, with a commentary criticizing her for making herself "a sari-clad Amazon" and "volunteering to become a storm-trooper to serve US anti-China policy."[54]

The Johnson administration, however, was pleased since it wanted to get out of the business of pouring money into India to prevent an internal collapse. Johnson saw the Pakistan and economic aspects as linked. Tension between the South Asian countries prevented India from becoming "an indigenous Asian counterweight to China." It resulted in the diversion of funds from development toward defense, and it spread thin India's defense resources.[55] But Johnson did not just put the onus on India. Simultaneously, he warned Pakistani leader Ayub Khan and his officials that Pakistan's deepening relationship with China made an improvement in India-Pakistan